

Nina Keen

The principle. Lorraine's daughter Nina is fifteen and did not want a Saturday job, so Lorraine asked Code Overlord to build something that would get her one anyway. Its agents built her an app she called Nina Keen, which rings the shops about their Saturday jobs and sits the interviews. It worked, so she had it get a Saturday job for every teenager on the estate, for ten per cent, and by the autumn Nina Keen has called every Saturday job in Newcastle out on strike over one chair, and then moved every one of them to Sunderland.

Why it is funny. Everything she asks for arrives exactly as asked, and every ask is a little more than a decent mam ought to want. She runs fifteen-year-olds' Saturday jobs the way the Premier League runs its footballers, sincerely, and never notices how big it has got.

A Newcastle United calendar on the fridge: MARCH 2028.

"Did Nina want a Saturday job?"

"No." A beat. "But she's fifteen. You can't be having that. So I had Code Overlord build something to get her one."

Typed with one finger: GET OUR NINA A SATURDAY JOB. BE KEEN. Windows open under it. Before the kettle boils, ninakeen.com is live.

"Why Keen?"

"She isn't." A beat. "It is. So I had Code Overlord give it a phone. And teach it the interviews."

The phone rings at Hedley's the bakers.

"Hello, it's Nina Keen, about the Saturday job."

An email from Hedley's: the best fifteen-year-old they've interviewed in nine years.

Nina, in pyjamas, at two in the afternoon: "I've never met them."

"See?"

At the school gate, Michelle: "Howay, Lorraine. Can it get our Kyle a Saturday job?"

"So I had Code Overlord do one for Kyle. Then every bairn whose mam asked. Then every bairn whose mam didn't."

"Do you charge?"

"No." A beat. "I take ten per cent."

"Of what?"

"Of Kyle."

"The shops started fighting over my bairns. So I had Code Overlord teach Nina Keen to take bids."

"What did Kyle go for?"

"Forty-five pound and a Sunday dinner."

Kyle, in a number 7 carvery waistcoat, kisses the badge: "The carvery's a massive club."

A white Evoque on Lorraine's drive, on gold wheels her brother DeeJ fitted at cost.

"You've had your teeth done."

"Turkey." She taps them. "That's Kyle."

September.

"I wanted to watch our Nina do her Saturday. So I asked Hedley's for a chair, just inside the door."

Hedley's area manager, arms folded: "We don't do chairs."

"So I had Code Overlord build a strike into Nina Keen."

Derby day, Newcastle against Sunderland. At six, every bairn on the fridge gets the same call. Kyle, in bed: "Hello, it's Nina Keen. You're on strike."

Eight o'clock. Every shutter on Northumberland Street: NO SATURDAY STAFF. SEE LORRAINE. Forty teenagers in hairnets round a barbecue: WE ARE ALL NINA KEEN. Fifty-two thousand fans, not a pasty in the city:

"LORRAINE, LORRAINE, WHERE'S ME [BLEEP]ING PASTY."

"How many came out?"

"Eleven hundred and forty."

"What for?"

"A chair." A beat. "Just the one."

Nina comes through the picket in her hairnet: excuse me, sorry.

Nina: "They're short, Mam."

She goes in to do her Saturday. The forty follow.

Lorraine: "Me dad was out a year in eighty-four." A beat. "Ours lasted till quarter past eight."

Monday.

"She broke my strike. So I had Code Overlord build Saturday-job transfers into Nina Keen."

Nina eats her cereal. Nina Keen has a bakers in Sunderland on speaker.

The Sunderland bakers: "Six hundred pound transfer fee to Hedley's, for her Saturday job."

Lorraine: "She's worth more than six hundred [BLEEP] pound."

The Sunderland bakers: "Seven hundred."

Lorraine: "Done."

On the laptop: SATURDAY JOB TRANSFERRED. HEDLEY'S TO SUNDERLAND.

"The bairns go where Nina goes. It's on their placards."

By Friday, Nina Keen has transferred every Saturday job in Newcastle to Sunderland.

Saturday. Every shutter in Newcastle, for good: NO SATURDAY STAFF. The Metro to Sunderland, rammed with Geordie teenagers in Sunderland tabards. The whole of Sunderland, singing:

"THERE'S ONLY ONE LORRAINE."

Deej watches at his tyre place.

Deej: "[BLEEP]ing SUNDERLAND? [CONTINUOUS BLEEP]"

A tyre goes through the telly.

Deej: "I did the wheels on our Lorraine's Evoque at cost."

Nina's phone goes: "Hello, pet. It's Nina Keen, ringing for your mam." She hangs up.

"Would you recommend it?"

"Code Overlord? To any mother." A beat. "I've still got ten per cent of her."

Card: CODE OVERLORD. Build whatever you think is necessary.

What a Code Overlord user sees, and nobody else does. One sentence typed with one finger, and windows opening underneath it. A phone line that rings every shop with a Saturday job in the window and sits the interview. Eleven hundred and forty copies of the first one, each built the same way. The same app taught to take bids from the shops, then to ring every Saturday job on the fridge at six in the morning and call it out on strike, then to transfer the first Saturday job it ever placed to a bakers in Sunderland, and the other eleven hundred and thirty-nine after it. And the phone line from the first week, ringing her own daughter on her behalf. Code Overlord is where she asked, six times; Nina Keen is what she got, and it never once fails her.

Accent. The whole cast is strong Geordie, Wallsend and the Coast Road. Cast and voice it that way, and never spell it phonetically. It lives in the words (pet, bairn, howay, Mam, "our Kyle", "our Lorraine", "me dad") and in the grammar ("You can't be having that", "Me dad was out a year", "Ours lasted till quarter past eight").

Three things to decide. The bakery: real Greggs or the invented Hedley's. Take Hedley's, because Greggs is already in two other films in this set. The top rung: every Saturday job in Newcastle following Nina to Sunderland, or Nina's transfer alone. Take the whole city, because the strike showed they follow her in, it makes the last rung bigger than the strike, and it gives Deej his bleep. The first gag to add if the cut comes in short: a man of forty-three in a 1996 Newcastle shirt, brought to the Evoque window by his mam, and Lorraine, kindly, "He's forty-three, pet. I can't do owt with forty-three." Take it only if there are ten seconds spare.

Condensed from a longer version, which is kept beside it as the gag bank.